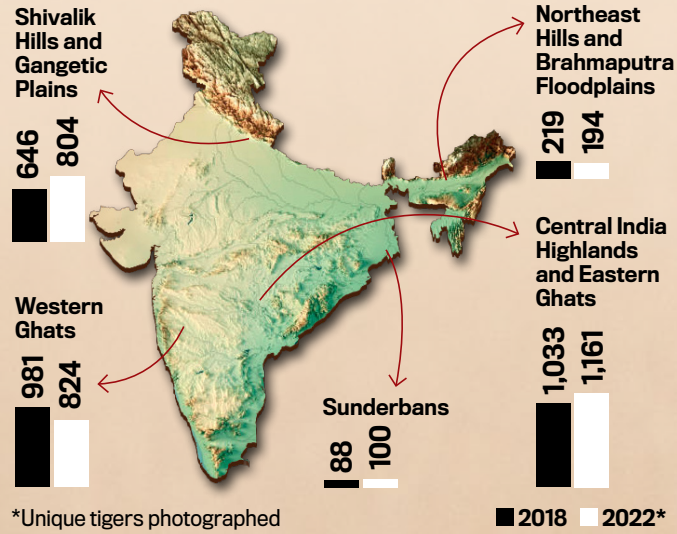
ROARING AND RISING

As Project Tiger—the ambitious conservation programme launched for the big cat in 1973—completes 50 years, there's some heartening news. The tiger numbers continue to rise in India, though at a slower rate, reveals the *Status of Tigers 2022* report released by PM Narendra Modi on April 9. The quadrennial report pegs India's tiger population at 3,167, up from the 2,967 estimated in 2018. Into its fifth edition, the countrywide assessment has used a refined and more extensive methodology, dividing tiger habitats into five landscapes. Broadly, there has been an increase in not just the numbers but also in the areas inhabited by the big cat. But is it time to rest on our laurels? Maybe not. While three landscapes have shown a rise in the tiger population, there has been a dip in two—the Western Ghats, and the Northeast Hills and the Brahmaputra floodplains. In the Western Ghats, which include the reserves in Tamil Nadu and Karnataka, unplanned development and forest degradation have been cited as the key reasons for the decline. But the overall upward trend proves the big cat has the tenacity and will to adapt, survive and thrive. **-RAHUL NORONHA**

TIGER HABITATS AND POPULATION



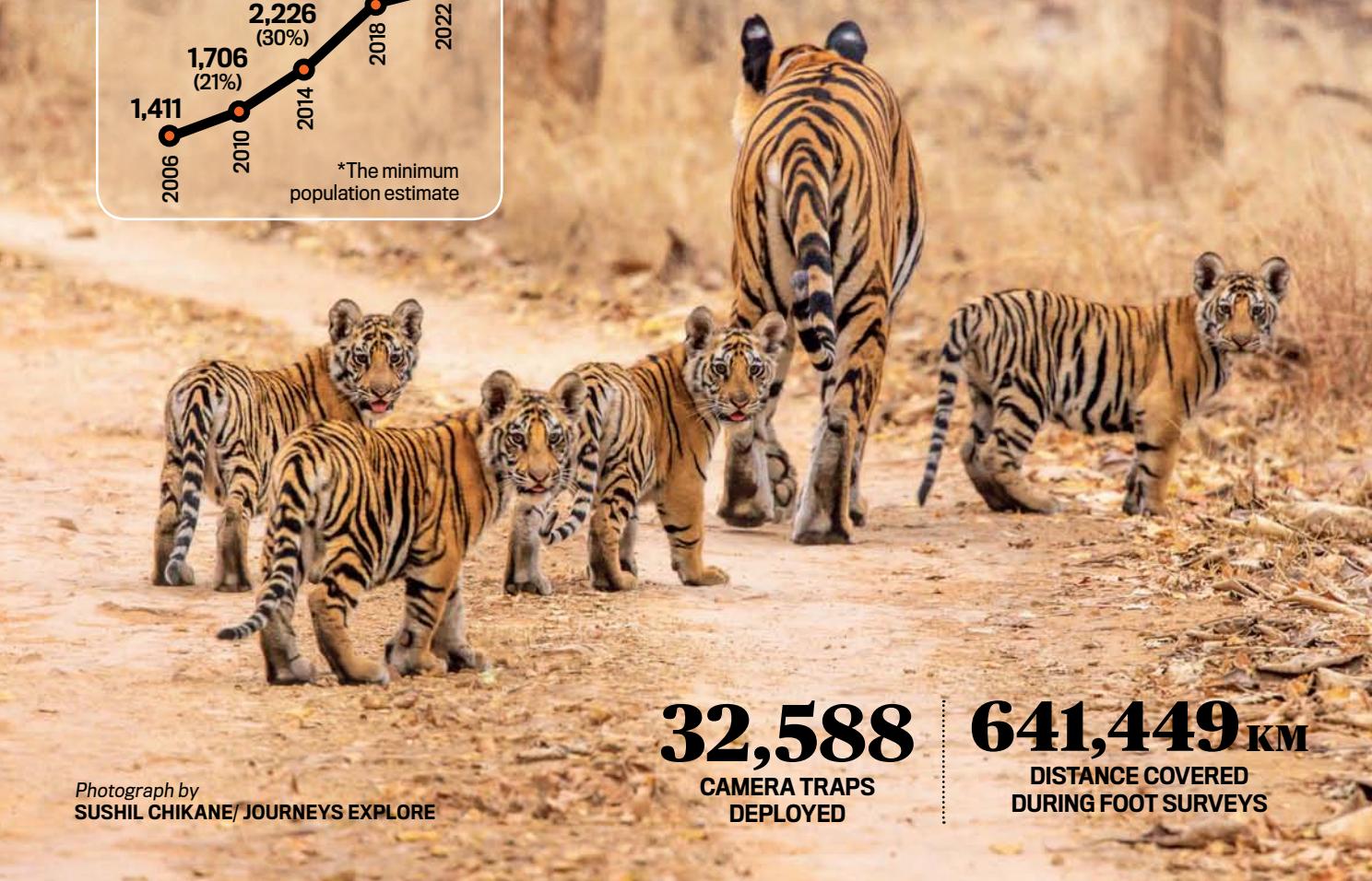
70%
INDIA'S SHARE IN GLOBAL TIGER POPULATION

53
TIGER RESERVES IN INDIA, UP FROM JUST 9 IN 1973

20
STATES COVERED IN CENSUS

AN UPWARD TRAJECTORY





32,588
CAMERA TRAPS DEPLOYED

641,449 KM
DISTANCE COVERED DURING FOOT SURVEYS

Photograph by
SUSHIL CHIKANE/ JOURNEYS EXPLORE